

The Legend of Sleepy Hollow

Washington Irving · 1820

First published: The Sketch Book, 1820

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

Liber et Libri · Lux et Libri LLC

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Sketchbook_of_Geoffrey_Crayon_(1819)/The_Legend_of_Sleepy_Hollow (revision 15829956), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 6–10 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Legend of Sleepy Hollow suggest about superstition and imagination?
- What does The Legend of Sleepy Hollow suggest about greed and courtship?
- What does The Legend of Sleepy Hollow suggest about rural community?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	The Legend of Sleepy Hollow	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*superstition and imagination* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: The Legend of Sleepy Hollow

Focus: superstition used against a credulous man

Content note (mild fright): Sensitive content: Mild fright. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes mild fright.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

In the Dutch hamlet of Sleepy Hollow, lanky, superstitious schoolmaster Ichabod Crane courts the heiress Katrina Van Tassel, partly for her father's rich farm. His rival is the strong prankster Brom Bones. After a party where ghost stories are told, Ichabod rides home and is chased by a Headless Horseman who hurls his head at him. Ichabod disappears; a shattered pumpkin is found. Brom marries Katrina and looks knowing when the tale is told.

Background: Published in 1820 in The Sketch Book, set in the Hudson Valley around 1790 near Tarrytown, New York.

Significance: A foundational American ghost story built on comic irony.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: Why do people enjoy being scared by stories? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes mild fright.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are tractable, peaches, preferment, imbibed, uselessly. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "He was in fact noted for preferring vicious animals, given to all kinds of tricks, which kept the rider in constant risk of his neck, for he held a tractable well-broken horse as unworthy of a lad of spirit." In this sentence it means: easy to manage or control. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of The Legend of Sleepy Hollow would have known. Published in 1820 in The Sketch Book, set in the Hudson Valley around 1790 near Tarrytown, New York. Why does this story matter? A foundational American ghost story built on comic irony. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for setting.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "It is remarkable that the visionary propensity I have mentioned, is not confined to the native inhabitants of the valley, but is unconsciously imbibed by every one who resides there for a time." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to superstition used against a credulous man? I circle "imbibed", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find setting, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for setting.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of setting. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *It is remarkable that the visionary propensity I have mentioned, is not confined to the native inhabitants of the valley, but is unconsciously imbibed by every one who resides there for a time. However wide awake they may have been before they entered that sleepy region, they are sure, in a little time, to inhale the witching influence of the air, and begin to grow imaginative—to dream dreams, and see apparitions.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Setting, Characterization, Tone / mood: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Legend of Sleepy Hollow develops the idea of superstition used against a credulous man. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to superstition and imagination? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about superstition used against a credulous man, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how setting shapes superstition used against a credulous man. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
tractable (adjective)	easy to manage or control	*He was in fact noted for preferring vicious animals, given to all kinds of tricks, which kept the rider in constant risk of his neck, for he held a tractable well-broken horse as unworthy of a lad of spirit.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
peaches (noun)	soft, round, sweet fruits with fuzzy skin	*She was a blooming lass of fresh eighteen; plump as a partridge; ripe and melting and rosy cheeked as one of her father's peaches, and universally famed, not merely for her beauty, but her vast expectations.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
preferment (noun)	promotion to a better position, especially in the church	*"Ergo, for a country schoolmaster to be refused the hand of a Dutch heiress, is a certain step to high preferment in the state."*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
imbibed (verb)	take in, also metaphorically	*It is remarkable that the visionary propensity I have mentioned, is not confined to the native inhabitants of the valley, but is unconsciously imbibed by every one who resides there for a time.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
uselessly (adverb)	without purpose	*A sloop was loitering in the distance, dropping slowly down with the tide, her sail hanging uselessly against the mast; and as the reflection of the sky gleamed along the still water, it seemed as if the vessel was suspended in the air.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
enraptured (verb)	hold spellbound	*Fain would I pause to dwell upon the world of charms that burst upon the enraptured gaze of my hero, as he entered the state parlor of Van Tassel's mansion.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
thwarted (verb)	hinder or prevent (the efforts, plans, or desires) of	*To have taken the field openly against his rival, would have been madness; for he was not man to be thwarted in his amours, any more than that stormy lover, Achilles.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
chestnuts (noun)	chestnut trees	*On that side of the road where the brook entered the wood, a group of oaks and chestnuts, matted thick with wild grape vines, threw a cavernous gloom over it.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
insinuating (adjective)	winning favor in a sly, flattering way	*Ichabod, therefore, made his advances in a quiet and gently-insinuating manner.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

despaired (verb)	abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart	*Such was the formidable rival with whom Ichabod Crane had to contend, and, considering all things, a stouter man than he would have shrunk from the competition, and a wiser man would have despaired.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Why do people enjoy being scared by stories?
2. Where does setting appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with superstition and imagination?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What is Ichabod Crane's job? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Schoolmaster
2. Why does Ichabod want to marry Katrina? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Partly for her father's wealth
3. Who is Ichabod's rival? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Brom Bones
4. What is found the next morning? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Ichabod's hat and a shattered pumpkin
5. Who is hinted to be the Headless Horseman? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Brom Bones
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Legend of Sleepy Hollow” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: In the Dutch hamlet of Sleepy Hollow, lanky, superstitious schoolmaster Ichabod Crane courts the heiress Katrina Van Tassel, partly for her father's rich farm. His rival is the strong prankster Brom Bones. After a party where ghost stories are told, Ichabod rides home and is chased by a Headless Horseman who hurls his head at him. Ichabod disappears; a shattered pumpkin is found. Brom marries…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Legend of Sleepy Hollow”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Legend of Sleepy Hollow” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “He was in fact noted for preferring vicious animals, given to all kinds of tricks, which kept the rider in constant risk of his neck, for he held a tractable well-broken horse as unworthy of a lad of spirit.” What does “tractable” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: tractable: easy to manage or control.

10. Reread: “She was a blooming lass of fresh eighteen; plump as a partridge; ripe and melting and rosy cheeked as one of her father's peaches, and universally famed, not merely for her beauty, but her vast expectations.” What does “peaches” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: peaches: soft, round, sweet fruits with fuzzy skin.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Legend of Sleepy Hollow” suggest about superstition used against a credulous man? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A foundational American ghost story built on comic irony.
2. Find one example of setting in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
3. How does the characterization in this story shape what we understand about superstition used against a credulous man? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. In the passage that begins “It is remarkable that the visionary propensity I have mentioned, is not confined to the native inhabitants of the valley, but is unconsciously imbibed by every one who resides…”, why might Irving have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Legend of Sleepy Hollow”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: In the Dutch hamlet of Sleepy Hollow, lanky, superstitious schoolmaster Ichabod Crane courts the heiress Katrina Van Tassel, partly for her father's rich farm. His rival is the strong prankster Brom Bones. After a party where ghost stories are told, Ichabod rides home and is chased by a Headless…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Legend of Sleepy Hollow” set up that the rest of The Legend of Sleepy Hollow will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “Why do people enjoy being scared by stories?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does tone / mood appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with superstition and imagination? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for word choices that reveal the narrator's attitude or the scene's feeling.
10. Background: Published in 1820 in The Sketch Book, set in the Hudson Valley around 1790 near Tarrytown, New York. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: "A foundational American ghost story built on comic irony." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of "The Legend of Sleepy Hollow" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about superstition used against a credulous man? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "The Legend of Sleepy Hollow": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to greed and courtship: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Irving need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the setting in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "The Legend of Sleepy Hollow" treats superstition used against a credulous man with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Legend of Sleepy Hollow see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve superstition and imagination? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about superstition used against a credulous man? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Washington Irving about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Setting:** look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Tone / mood**: word choices that reveal the narrator's attitude or the scene's feeling

Chapter quiz

1. What is Ichabod Crane's job?

   A. Farmer

B. Schoolmaster

C. Minister

D. Blacksmith

2. Why does Ichabod want to marry Katrina?

A. To leave town

B. For her singing

C. Partly for her father's wealth

D. Because Brom tells him to

3. Who is Ichabod's rival?

A. Baltus Van Tassel

B. Brom Bones

C. The Horseman

D. Hans Van Ripper

4. What is found the next morning?

A. Ichabod's hat and a shattered pumpkin

B. Ichabod's body

C. A sword

D. A horse's head

5. Who is hinted to be the Headless Horseman?

A. The narrator

B. Brom Bones

C. Ichabod himself

D. Katrina

6. In the line “He was in fact noted for preferring vicious animals, given to all kinds of tricks, which kept the rider in constant risk of his neck, for he held a tractable well-broken horse as unworthy of a lad of spirit.”, what does “tractable” most nearly mean?

A. soft, round, sweet fruits with fuzzy skin

B. easy to manage or control

C. take in, also metaphorically

D. promotion to a better position, especially in the church

7. In the line “She was a blooming lass of fresh eighteen; plump as a partridge; ripe and melting and rosy cheeked as one of her father's peaches, and universally famed, not merely for her beauty, but her vast expectations.”, what does “peaches” most nearly mean?

A. soft, round, sweet fruits with fuzzy skin

B. easy to manage or control

C. promotion to a better position, especially in the church

D. take in, also metaphorically

Answer key: 1. B (Schoolmaster); 2. C (Partly for her father's wealth); 3. B (Brom Bones); 4. A (Ichabod's hat and a shattered pumpkin); 5. B (Brom Bones); 6. B (easy to manage or control); 7. A (soft, round, sweet fruits with fuzzy skin)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.3, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Legend of Sleepy Hollow,” how does Irving show superstition used against a credulous man? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the setting you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In The Legend of Sleepy Hollow, how does Irving develop the idea of superstition used against a credulous man? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the setting in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Legend of Sleepy Hollow develops the idea of superstition used against a credulous man. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Legend of Sleepy Hollow (where it begins, turns and ends) and its setting shape the reader's understanding of superstition used against a credulous man. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Legend of Sleepy Hollow suggests about superstition used against a credulous man. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's setting and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Washington Irving uses setting in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow to complicate the reader's understanding of superstition used against a credulous man. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Legend of Sleepy Hollow within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of superstition used against a credulous man responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Legend of Sleepy Hollow alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of superstition used against a credulous man follows or bends those conventions, using the setting as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Legend of Sleepy Hollow and its treatment of superstition used against a credulous man. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's setting and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Legend of Sleepy Hollow as evidence for a larger claim about superstition used against a credulous man in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Legend of Sleepy Hollow as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of superstition used against a credulous man. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Legend of Sleepy Hollow.

SAT-style questions

1. *"Ergo, for a country schoolmaster to be refused the hand of a Dutch heiress, is a certain step to high preferment in the state."*

   As used in the text, what does the word “preferment” most nearly mean?

   A. abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart

   B. winning favor in a sly, flattering way

   C. promotion to a better position, especially in the church

   D. chestnut trees

2. *It is remarkable that the visionary propensity I have mentioned, is not confined to the native inhabitants of the valley, but is unconsciously imbibed by every one who resides there for a time. However wide awake they may have been before they entered that sleepy region, they are sure, in a little time, to inhale the witching influence of the air, and begin to grow imaginative—to dream dreams, and see apparitions.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Legend of Sleepy Hollow”?

   A. The futile attempt to shut out death

   B. Superstition used against a credulous man

   C. Enemies reconciled too late

   D. The loss of faith in human goodness

SAT key: 1. C (promotion to a better position, especially in the church); 2. B (Superstition used against a credulous man)

Whole-book test

The Legend of Sleepy Hollow: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. What is Ichabod Crane's job?
   A. Farmer
   B. Schoolmaster
   C. Minister
   D. Blacksmith
2. Why does Ichabod want to marry Katrina?
   A. To leave town
   B. For her singing
   C. Partly for her father's wealth
   D. Because Brom tells him to
3. Who is Ichabod's rival?
   A. Baltus Van Tassel
   B. Brom Bones
   C. The Horseman
   D. Hans Van Ripper
4. What is found the next morning?
   A. Ichabod's hat and a shattered pumpkin
   B. Ichabod's body
   C. A sword
   D. A horse's head
5. Who is hinted to be the Headless Horseman?
   A. The narrator
   B. Brom Bones
   C. Ichabod himself
   D. Katrina
6. In the line “He was in fact noted for preferring vicious animals, given to all kinds of tricks, which kept the rider in constant risk of his neck, for he held a tractable well-broken horse as unworthy of a lad of spirit.”, what does “tractable” most nearly mean?
   A. soft, round, sweet fruits with fuzzy skin
   B. easy to manage or control
   C. take in, also metaphorically
   D. promotion to a better position, especially in the church

7. In the line “She was a blooming lass of fresh eighteen; plump as a partridge; ripe and melting and rosy cheeked as one of her father's peaches, and universally famed, not merely for her beauty, but her vast expectations.”, what does “peaches” most nearly mean?
   A. soft, round, sweet fruits with fuzzy skin
   B. easy to manage or control
   C. promotion to a better position, especially in the church
   D. take in, also metaphorically
8. As used in the story (“He was in fact noted for preferring vicious animals, given to all kinds of tricks, which kept the rider in constant risk of his neck, for he”), what does “tractable” mean?
   A. easy to manage or control
   B. without purpose
   C. chestnut trees
   D. soft, round, sweet fruits with fuzzy skin
9. As used in the story (“She was a blooming lass of fresh eighteen; plump as a partridge; ripe and melting and rosy cheeked as one of her father's peaches, and unive”), what does “peaches” mean?
   A. hold spellbound
   B. soft, round, sweet fruits with fuzzy skin
   C. winning favor in a sly, flattering way
   D. promotion to a better position, especially in the church
10. As used in the story (“"Ergo, for a country schoolmaster to be refused the hand of a Dutch heiress, is a certain step to high preferment in the state."”), what does “preferment” mean?
    A. hinder or prevent (the efforts, plans, or desires) of
    B. abandon hope; give up hope; lose heart
    C. promotion to a better position, especially in the church
    D. take in, also metaphorically
11. As used in the story (“It is remarkable that the visionary propensity I have mentioned, is not confined to the native inhabitants of the valley, but is unconscious”), what does “imbibed” mean?
    A. chestnut trees
    B. easy to manage or control
    C. without purpose
    D. take in, also metaphorically
12. As used in the story (“A sloop was loitering in the distance, dropping slowly down with the tide, her sail hanging uselessly against the mast; and as the reflectio”), what does “uselessly” mean?
    A. without purpose
    B. winning favor in a sly, flattering way
    C. soft, round, sweet fruits with fuzzy skin
    D. hold spellbound

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how superstition and imagination develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how greed and courtship develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how rural community develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (superstition and imagination, greed and courtship, rural community) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. B (Schoolmaster); 2. C (Partly for her father's wealth); 3. B (Brom Bones); 4. A (Ichabod's hat and a shattered pumpkin); 5. B (Brom Bones); 6. B (easy to manage or control); 7. A (soft, round, sweet fruits with fuzzy skin); 8. A (easy to manage or control); 9. B (soft, round, sweet fruits with fuzzy skin); 10. C (promotion to a better position, especially in the church); 11. D (take in, also metaphorically); 12. A (without purpose)

Essay assignments

Essay: Superstition and imagination

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Legend of Sleepy Hollow teaches about superstition and imagination. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Washington Irving develops superstition and imagination in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Washington Irving develops superstition and imagination across The Legend of Sleepy Hollow. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Legend of Sleepy Hollow (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of superstition and imagination. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of superstition and imagination in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Washington Irving's choices in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of superstition and imagination, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Legend of Sleepy Hollow's treatment of superstition and imagination in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on superstition and imagination in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on superstition and imagination in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow.

Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about superstition and imagination in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on superstition and imagination in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Greed and courtship

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Legend of Sleepy Hollow teaches about greed and courtship. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Washington Irving develops greed and courtship in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Washington Irving develops greed and courtship across The Legend of Sleepy Hollow. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Legend of Sleepy Hollow (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of greed and courtship. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of greed and courtship in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Washington Irving's choices in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of greed and courtship, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Legend of Sleepy Hollow's treatment of greed and courtship in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on greed and courtship in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on greed and courtship in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about greed and courtship in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on greed and courtship in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Rural community

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Legend of Sleepy Hollow teaches about rural community. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Washington Irving develops rural community in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Washington Irving develops rural community across The Legend of Sleepy Hollow. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Legend of Sleepy Hollow (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of rural community. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of rural community in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Washington Irving's choices in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of rural community, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Legend of Sleepy Hollow's treatment of rural community in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on rural community in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on rural community in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about rural community in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on rural community in The Legend of Sleepy Hollow, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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